

music

Queen's Play

In the 1930s, women following their passion were a rarity and were looked down upon by society. Their venturing out of house for not just cinema and theatre but also for learning music was actively discouraged. A product of such time, Sharan Rani Backliwal or Sarod Rani as she was fondly called did the impossible. She forayed into a male-dominated

world and literally mastered the art of playing sarod. Trained under the legendary Baba Allaadin Khan in Maihar of Madhya Pradesh, she was the only other woman to have learnt from him, the first being his own daughter, Annapurna Devi. "She was a trendsetter," says sarangi maestro Pandit Ram Narayan.

Sharan Rani was a fine musician and a humanist. She donated more than 500 old and rare Indian classical music instruments from her personal collec-

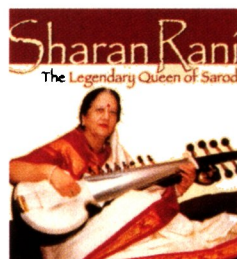
tion to the National Museum in Delhi. The erudite musician also authored the book *The Divine Sarod, Its Origin, Antiquity and Development in India, since 2nd Century BC*.

As a tribute to this great maestro, Music Today has launched a special two-CD album pack, *Sharan Rani—The Legendary Queen of Sarod*, featuring some of her rare recordings. It was a quirk of fate that she died the day the CDs were launched on April 8. The album includes a

booklet which has photographs of her most prized moments from her personal library. The first CD features the popular ragas of her gharana—raga Miyan ki

Todi and raga Kausi Kanhada—magnificently rendered by her with Debashish Chakraborty on the tabla. She gives her finest rendition of ragas—Shree, Puriya Dhanashri and Mishra Maand. These ragas are featured in the second CD. Don't miss the magical music of an era gone by.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit



Music Today
Rs 399

ONE OF HER KIND: Sharan Rani



art exhibition

A Bright Spark

KOLKATA That something as mundane and commonplace as the electric bulb can provide the spark for a whole series of paintings was proved by the sheer genius of Debraj Goswami at the Akar Prakar Gallery. A part of his solo exhibition, the paintings that catch your eye the minute you enter the gallery are the ones where Thomas Alva Edison's invention has metamorphosed into works of art. Goswami's paintings draw their strength from the constant struggle between his beliefs and the shifting goal posts of reality. In one of the exhibits, the viewer will almost be stunned at the ease with which a rifle is placed inside a soft-drink bottle, very much in the manner a harmless straw should be. His paintings are mostly acrylic on canvas, and the bold use of colours adds strength and character to each piece. On till April 24.

by Elora Sen

GUIDING LIGHT: Goswami's work titled Choice 7



art

Drifting with Fancy

MUMBAI The last time Martin OC exhibited in Kochi, he was *Waiting for a New Vision*. This time in *Adrift*, he explores the meticulously painted surface. Water becomes a steady backdrop for oddly shaped and coloured objects and concrete, iron, rust and plastic lend an overwhelming feel to the



Martin's work artwork. "I like to think of myself as something that gets carried away by a current, an obstacle-less flow of water," says Martin. On till April 26 at Gallery Beyond.

by Swati Mathur